ENGR 4010 - PDLC LEAD RPG Game Rules & Mechanics

This is a cooperative narrative system. We play by co-creating our world and using a D20 die system to help us understand the consequences of decisions and experience navigating ambiguity and uncertainty – both are important leadership competencies!

These game rules are a foundation, and as we build our world, we will add, adjust, and clarify these rules together.

Unless specified before the game, no use of phones or computers while in gameplay.

The Dice: This game primarily uses a twenty-sided die (D20).

Skill Checks: When a character attempts an action that has a chance of failure or varying degrees of success, they perform a skill check. This involves rolling the die and adding any relevant bonuses (e.g., a skill/leadership competency or equipment bonus).

Characters' Leadership Competencies/Engineering Skills/Tools	**Relevant Bonus**
Action uses a Leadership Competency	+3
Action uses Engineering Skills	+2
Action uses Tool	+1

Setting Difficulties: As the GM, you will set a difficulty for actions. This is a number that players must meet or exceed with their dice roll to succeed. If they get close but don't succeed, it is engaging and fun to give them a partial success that comes with a twist. You want to avoid situations where the result is "nothing happens" or they don't get any new information.

DC	Type	DC	Type
20	Legendary	8-10	Average
17-19	Heroic	5-7	Easy
14-16	Great	2-4	Simple
11-13	Good	1	Catastrophic

Rolling the Dice: When a player declares an action, the facilitator prompts them to roll the die and add any applicable modifiers. Compare the total to the difficulty you set.

Dice outcomes

Roll-DC	Title	Narrative Description
+3	Succeed with a boon	Success with a major benefit
0 (at target)	Near success	Come close and then succeed
-1 or -2	Near miss	Partial success with complication/cost
-3 or -4	Fail with a twist	Fail with a minor benefit
-5 or more	Fail with consequences	Fail with a major complication

Success with a Boon: If the total exceeds the difficulty by 3 or more, the action succeeds and includes a major benefit.

Near Success: If the total meets the difficulty, the action comes close and ends up succeeding

Near Miss: If the roll is close to the difficulty but not quite there, only 1-2 off, consider a partial success where the action gets some kind of result but with some complication, or different than what the player intended.

Fail with a Twist: If the total is less than the DC by 3-4, the action does not go as intended. The action itself fails, but there are other minor benefits that may happen as a result or in addition to the action failure.

Fail with Consequences: If the total is less than the DC by 5 or more, the action fails with a major complication. Use this to make things interesting by presenting unintended consequences or presenting new challenges that still move the story forward and engage the players more than being punishing

Interpreting Results: Use the results of the dice rolls to narrate the story. Describe the outcomes vividly to keep the players engaged.
Example: If a player rolls a 17 to use a microscope and the difficulty was 15, you might say, "You peer through the microscope and clearly see evidence of life swarming in the sample, confirming your suspicions. And what's more, you notice something else…"

Example: If a player rolls an 8 to get information from a non-player character (NPC) and the difficulty was 10, you might say, "Despite your best efforts, they remains unconvinced and refuse to share any information. But, you notice out of the corner of your eye that they keep glancing over towards…"

Encouraging Creativity: If players come up with creative actions, reward them by lowering the difficulty or incorporating their idea somehow even if the dice fail. This encourages out-of-the-box thinking and makes the game more dynamic.